

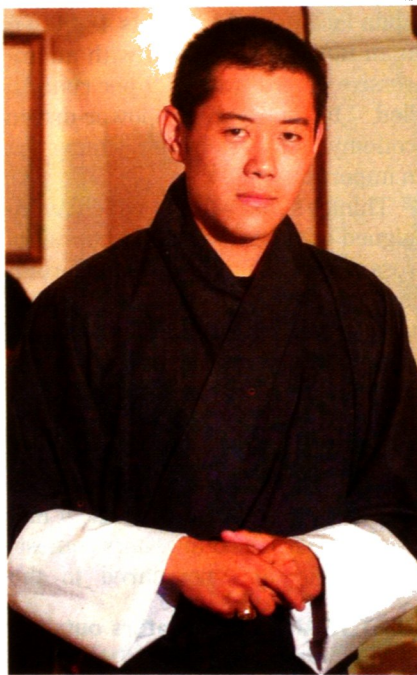
was smooth without the pomp and fanfare of an Indian election. For voters, election ID cards were mandatory and only graduates could contest. The Election Commission handed out rules on fund-raising limits, the size of posters were defined, and even the places were well marked. Monks were ineligible to vote, in order to keep religious institutions above politics. Each candidate was given out Rs 1 lakh by the Election Commission besides the election material. They were allowed to spend another Rs 1 lakh collected only from registered party members.

For India, the Bhutan elections are important as it has crucial stakes in the Himalayan nation, with Thimphu being its closest strategic friend in the region surrounded by uncertainty and conflict. Strategically located, Bhutan is a buffer between India and China, and has steadfastly protected India's security interests by taking action against the North-east insurgent groups, which were earlier operating from its territory. In 2003, the present king's father had himself led his troops to attack militant camps.

The intensity of this relationship has grown. The two neighbours updated the 1949 Indo-Bhutan Friendship Treaty last year, which commits both countries to cooperate closely with each other on issues relating to their national interests, and not allow the use of their territories for ac-

tance is expected to go up. "Having a stable, peaceful, prosperous, democratic and trustworthy ally in the form of Bhutan will boost India's development prospects and stability in the neighbourhood. It also helps in India's aspiration to be a larger global player," says an Indian official. With bulk of India facing an acute power shortage, and with most Indian cities facing a harrowing summer of power outages, Bhutan holds a huge promise for solving India's growing power crisis.

Bhutan's economy is completely



and become broad-based under a democratic government," says India's Ambassador to Bhutan, Sudhir Vyas.

The clock of modernisation has started ticking in Bhutan. Television, including satellite channels, and Internet which were allowed in only in the last decade, are gaining popularity. However, MTV and WWF stay on the banned list because the government believes that it has a potentially harmful effect on youth. Women enjoy equal rights. The government is now planning to bring international schools to Bhutan. Live-in relationships are becoming common and almost every second shop in the capital has a makeshift bar. Despite modernisation, Bhutan still wants to preserve its unique identity. Its national dresses—knee-length skirt for men called gho, and a gown for women called keera—are mandatory. Violation of this dress code is allowed only on Sunday and national holidays; on other days a fine is levied.

Democracy has also brought with it a new set of challenges. The government will have to tackle the emerging threats emanating from Maoist groups gaining ground around the Bhutan-Nepal border. The imbroglio over the deportation of over one lakh Nepalese refugees from Bhutan in 1991, still remains unresolved. In fact, the elections were marred by a series of low intensity bomb blasts by suspected Maoist groups, which are now active in south-

"Under democracy I'll have more time to spend with people."

JIGME KHE SAR NAMGYEL WANGCHUCK, KING OF BHUTAN

tivities harmful to the national security and interest of the other. Even though Bhutan is now free to follow its own foreign policy, it is aligned to India's security interests. In regional organisations like SAARC and at international organisations like the United Nations, Bhutan has been a strong supporter of India.

It has always been a mutually recognised relationship based on the fact that both countries cannot do without each other. Indian assistance to Bhutan has been key to its socio-economic development. In the Tenth Five Year Plan, Indian assistance to Bhutan was worth Rs 2,610 crore, and Delhi is currently discussing the priorities of the 11th Plan where the level of assis-

linked to India. The two sides have a free trade agreement and India accounts for 92 per cent of the nation's total trade of Rs 2,750 crore. The rupee, which is at par with Bhutanese currency Ngultrum, circulates freely within the country, and India provides subsidies on essential products like kerosene and LPG. Apart from training the Bhutan Army, the Indian Army maintains a substantial presence in the country. The Indian Air Force manages the air traffic control at Paro, Bhutan's only airport. "India-Bhutan relationship is based on firm foundations of trust and mutual respect and has grown under His Majesty's leadership and our engagement will only deepen

ern Bhutan. Even though under a settlement reached with the western countries, the US and other European countries are taking these refugees to their country, the future remittances from these refugees could fuel the revolt against Thimphu. The country still has poor infrastructure and health facility, which should be the priority of the new government. For India the priority will be to work in Bhutan with a degree of proactive and out-of-the-box diplomacy respecting the sensitivities of Bhutan to ensure that the goodwill stays intact. For now the new rulers have a big task at their hands—of ensuring that real power percolates to the people.